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Exploring young consumer's adoption of secondhand luxury: insights from a qualitative study

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Abstract

Purpose – This study explores reasons for and against secondhand luxury (SHL) fashion adoption among young consumers in an emerging nation, India. As a trend, SHL has witnessed tremendous growth in the past few years, but scholarly interest remains scant.

Design/methodology/approach – Drawing from an interpretivist paradigm, this study uses an exploratory qualitative approach with 26 semi-structured interviews with SHL buyers, analyzed using NVivo software.

Findings – The findings shed significant light on value drivers and find support for status value, uniqueness value, quality value and monetary value, while adding the role of emotional value in reasons for SHL adoption. The results reveal an interesting trait of Indian consumers: price, fashion and celebrity association outweigh sustainability concerns, where an attitude–behavior gap is observed. Also, the findings add depth to risk perceptions as a major reason against SHL adoption.

Originality/value – While most existing studies have only focused on the motivational drivers, this study offers in-depth insights into the growing SHL literature by drawing attention to the enablers and equally important inhibitors by applying the novel Behavioral Reasoning Theory. It also intends to enhance practitioner knowledge in understanding a culturally diverse market and developing strategies relevant to a new set of consumers. The study calls for SHL retailers to sensitize young consumers in India about the sustainability aspect of SHL consumption, which is currently less appreciated.

Keywords Luxury, Secondhand fashion, Millennials, Emerging economies, Qualitative research

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

Growing concern for the planet and an intensifying urge to experience luxury have led to alternative consumption forms (Agrawal *et al.*, 2022). Resultantly, the secondhand luxury (SHL) market is accelerating four times faster than the luxury industry's growth (Luxebook, 2020). SHL, also known as pre-owned or pre-loved luxury, are high-end products that are previously owned and used (Jain and Rathi, 2023). The premier consumer segment shaping sustainable consumption are young adults, i.e. millennials (or Generation Y, those born between 1980 and 1994) and Generation Z (those born between 1995 and 2015) (Beresford, 2023). These are consumption-oriented shoppers (Rodrigues and Rodrigues, 2019), and their adoption of secondhand fashion is 2.5 times faster than older generations (ThredUp, 2021).

This study identified young adult SHL consumers from India, because it has newly become a luxury destination compared to mature Asian markets like China and Korea (Quach and Thaichon, 2017). The International Monetary Fund has predicted India as the only major economy foreseeing a double-digit growth in 2021, paving the way for the Indian

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luxury market to surpass US$200bn by 2030 (India Retailing, 2021). Moreover, Indian millennials differ from their Western equivalents in aspiring to positively impact personal, political, economic and environmental fronts, making it crucial to fathom the young consumer mindset about SHL (Deloitte Millennial Survey, 2019). Culturally, secondhand is customary in Indian households and giving away unused belongings to someone in need is a common practice (Kaur *et al.*, 2022). However, commercializing this deeply rooted trend is still in the embryonic stages. It has not become a part of consumer habits, making it crucial to explore how far the consumer mindset has reached while acclimatizing with SHL.

The rising popularity of luxury resale is reflected in academic research on circularity and collaborative consumption (Pantano and Stylos, 2020). Through previous research, significant consumer-focused themes have emerged: determinants of vintage and SHL purchase (Battle *et al.*, 2018); antecedents for SHL consumption (Kessous and Valette-Florence, 2019); positive aspects of access-based models (Hu *et al.*, 2019); creativity and nostalgia as motivations to buy SHL (Stolz, 2022); and values shaping SHL consumption (Jain and Rathi, 2023), where the emphasis has been on the factors that drive this consumption (Ryding *et al.*, 2017) (Table I). More specifically, the existing studies have focused on the reasons that facilitate SHL consumption, while the equally essential inhibitors or barriers have been overlooked. Sahu *et al.* (2022) stress that any consumer-focused research analyzing behavior and intention should factor in enablers, i.e. reasons causing facilitation, and inhibitors, i.e. reasons causing resistance. The inherent quantitative differences between enablers and inhibitors make them prone to affect consumer behavior differently (Dhir *et al.*, 2021). Although the available literature has contributed to an early understanding of SHL models and their adoption motivations, a holistic view with joint insights into motivational and resistance factors is missing, especially for a young demographic. Since young consumers are "more active in the secondhand luxury market than average" (BCG, 2019) but secondhand is stigmatized in India (Jain and Rathi, 2023), there lies a critical gap in academic knowledge of the reasons to resist purchasing SHL that needs exploration. The purpose of this research is to bridge this gap of partial inclusion by grounding in the Behavioral Reasoning Theory (BRT) and deeply understanding consumers' intention to engage with and resist SHL. BRT is an emerging theory that comprehensively provides insights into consumers' intentions and behavioral actions. More importantly, it expounds on the acceptance and resistance factors in a single unified framework. An integration of reasons that are conceptually contrary can establish a deeper understanding of the intentional and behavioral motivations of SHL consumers.

This study bridges the above-mentioned gaps through four research objectives: First, to re-examine the inconsistent and fragmented findings of past research themes and reconcile all the factors (for and against) leading to SHL consumption. Second, to redefine and add dimensions to critical factors identified through an exhaustive review of SHL literature by an in-depth qualitative study, leading to a comprehensive model for wider academic and practitioner application. Third, to add significantly to academic knowledge on SHL, employ a holistic albeit sparsely used theoretical grounding into BRT. Fourth, to enhance the understanding of SHL by providing a culturally different perspective and insights into the Indian market. By rooting the SHL concept into BRT, findings should steer meaningful discourse among academicians and practitioners while anchoring SHL as an emerging area of investigation. The paper further presents the literature, research methodology and findings, implications, future research directions and limitations.

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2. Literature review

2.1 Secondhand luxury consumption

Secondhand consumption is "the acquisition of secondhand objects through methods and places of exchange that are generally distinct from those for new products" (Guiot and Roux, 2010, p. 356). Over the last decade, SHL fashion has been popularized and de-stigmatized. Rather than being associated with low-income status, SHL has become cool and accessible (Battle *et al.*, 2018). Asian consumers have hesitated to adopt secondhand due to stigma but have recently embraced SHL (Tu *et al.*, 2022), overcoming social embarrassment (Cervellon and Vigreux, 2018). In collectivistic societies like India, as the focus is on an enhanced social image, these consumers are slowly shifting toward a more sustainable way to consume luxury by adopting SHL (Jain and Rathi, 2023). A review of prior SHL literature indicates scholarly interest in consumer intention and resulting behavior. Battle *et al.* (2018) attempt to explain various SHL business models by drawing comparisons among swapping, fashion libraries, renting and sharing. This proliferation is not limited to the meanings consumers attach to buying SHL (Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen, 2015) or consumer experience and emotions (Cervellon and Vigreux, 2018). Much SHL research has captured the motivations for SHL consumption (Turunen *et al.*, 2018). These motivations are fueled by young adults who are high earners and exorbitant spenders with a value-for-money attitude (Jain and Mishra, 2020). This consumer segment is lucrative as there is tremendous growth opportunity in the Indian SHL market between 2023 and 2028 (IMARC, 2023). Still, empirical evidence is insufficient in capturing what SHL means to Indian consumers. There is a gap in a holistic understanding of SHL that uncovers its positives and equally emphasizes the inhibitions consumers may face keeping a culturally diverse perspective in mind.

2.2 Behavioral Reasoning Theory

Consumer behavior literature extensively uses behavioral theories to study decision-making, intention and behavior toward specific products and services. Among these is a relatively new theory in the marketing realm, BRT (Westaby, 2005), that explains context-specific adoption and resistance factors in a single framework. Researchers argue that BRT is an extension of widely accepted behavior intention theories – Theory of Planned Behavior and Theory of Reasoned Action as it addresses their limitations and expands their scope (Dhir *et al.*, 2021). BRT holistically captures reasons (for and against) by providing context-specific insights to interpret consumer decision-making better. Interestingly, these measures are not logically opposite but rather influence a phenomenon. Reasons constitute a significant component of the BRT model and are argued to be drivers of decision-making and intention formation. Sahu *et al.* (2022) highlight that reasons (for and against) predict consumer behavior, justify and defend consumer judgments and further enhance the acceptability of these judgments. Extant literature also supports that behavioral change is subject to accounting for the underlying reasons driving a specific behavior.

Previous studies in various domains have been conceptually grounded in BRT. They have emphasized that there is more to the framework than being logically opposite in a leadership decision-making scenario (Westaby, 2005). The innovation adoption (Gupta and Arora, 2017), mobile banking and e-waste recycling literature (Dhir *et al.*, 2021) also extensively see the implications of BRT. Luxury research, however, lacks in acknowledging the potential of collating diverse antecedents in one framework. Likewise, SHL studies have covered many aspects of consumer behavior. Still, they fail to recognize and holistically identify adoption and resistance factors distinctly. As highlighted by Dhir *et al.* (2021), enablers and inhibitors affect consumption behavior differently. Secondhand, being

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a stigmatized concept, demands an emphasis on the reasons for consumer unwillingness to adopt as much as studying its motivations. Thus, BRT is an appropriate theory to uncover different facets of SHL consumer behavior as it integrates the two perspectives (for and against) and provides granular insights into the behavioral reasons toward SHL. This study further consolidates these conceptually distinct adoption motivations and resistance barriers and presents them in a single framework.

2.3 Reasons for adoption of secondhand luxury

A growing body of consumer behavior research documents various motivational drivers of purchasing luxury from secondary markets. This section reviews the existing motivational drivers in SHL literature, establishing the former element of BRT, i.e. reasons for adoption. The first is status value. The aspects of a brand or product beyond its tangible attributes form symbolic meanings and are psychological. Consumers associate symbolic status dimensions and desirability with their luxury possessions. This is consistent with SHL as consumers associate brand meanings and long for status in social contexts (Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen, 2015). Next, the uniqueness aspects have been discussed. Uniqueness significantly impacts consumer behavior. It explains how consumers recognize a constant need to feel different from others in their social groups. Luxury products enable consumers to express uniqueness (Butcher *et al.*, 2017). SHL research indicates that consumers represent their identities and stand out from the masses by possessing unique products (Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen, 2015). These are generally found in *limited edition* collections and *limited quantity* launches. Previous work of Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen (2015) states that a unique product enhances positive SHL experiences. Next, the literature has immensely focused on the monetary aspects of SHL consumption. Striking good deals and enjoying a good value for money emerged as major motivations behind SHL purchases. Bargain shopping and price evaluations have been studied for a long time (Kwon *et al.*, 2010), and the SHL market is closely associated with these principles.

Consumers are drawn toward spending only a fraction on coveted luxury products while saving money (Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen, 2015). Finally, secondary markets are associated with environment-friendly practices and bring forth the eco-conscious behavior of individuals (Guiot and Roux, 2010). Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen (2015) found it intriguing to investigate whether SHL also invokes similar behavior and found that engaging with sustainability was one of the major drivers for consumers purchasing luxury from resale markets. Cervellon *et al.* (2012) also associate SHL with the conscientious nature of consumers who are more drawn toward a sustainable lifestyle. Interestingly, Joung and Park-Paops (2013) posited that as much as SHL portrays a bent toward sustainability and ethicality, such consumption is equally against materialism and consumerism. Eco-conscious consumers purchase luxury from resale markets as a statement toward downshifting and against overconsumption (Shaw and Newholm, 2002).

2.4 Reasons against the adoption of secondhand luxury

Research on the factors that cause SHL resistance is scant and offers limited insights. However, it is critical to explore the latter facet of BRT theory, i.e. reasons against adopting SHL. Research poses a risk as the main factor causing SHL inhibition. In high-involvement luxury products, perceived risks largely affect the purchase decisions and cause post-purchase dissonance. In their research, Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen (2015) proposed five themes, one of which was risk investment. The researchers highlight risks on financial and reputational fronts. Naturally, consumers seek financial value when buying from secondary markets. However, they lack confidence in secondhand players and fear losing money if the product does not turn out as expected. Additionally, consumers experience

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reputational inhibitions due to the despising nature of secondhand products. Another major risk is consumers' perception of counterfeit products that evoke unpleasant emotions and experiences (Beverland, 2006). The meanings associated with SHL drastically alter as consumers view themselves as engaging in a risky investment.

3. Methodology

3.1 Qualitative research

A qualitative study was designed to comprehensively gauge the specificities of luxury consumers' motivations and inhibitions during pre-owned purchases. The qualitative approach supports understanding the complex and multifaceted nature of pre-owned luxury consumers' psyche. Furthermore, it adds to luxury research by deeply analyzing their motivations and inhibitions not yet explored in a culturally diverse context. Such research design allows for a more nuanced exploration of cultural factors and can help researchers gain a deeper understanding of the symbolic and emotional significance of SHL goods in India. The Indian culture exhibits complex social and cultural phenomena such as social norms, values and beliefs (Eng and Bogaert, 2010) that are difficult to quantify. With regard to SHL, Indian consumers also differ from their Western counterparts in their perceived readiness for adoption, attitude toward the products and perceived risks (Jain and Rathi, 2023). Thus, qualitative research is better suited. While past studies highlight pro-environmentalism as a major driver, Indian consumers possess limited knowledge with regard to green products (Khare, 2014), and while they have adopted a lot of Western value systems, adopting the secondhand regime would still require time and awareness. Therefore, the motivation for SHL consumption for Westerners might be an inhibition for Indian consumers. These differences call for an exploratory research design, as granular insights into Indian SHL consumption are missing from the literature.

To meet the broad objectives of this research, consumers who have purchased from SHL platforms at least once were recruited by asking a qualifying question: "Do you have any experience of purchasing pre-owned luxury products in the recent past?", thus employing purposive sampling. Additionally, snowball sampling was used as each respondent was further asked to recruit two pre-owned luxury fashion buyer acquaintances, ensuring homogeneity in the respondent profile.

In-depth telephonic and face-to-face semi-structured interviews were conducted. For exploratory studies, the interview technique provides meticulous and rigorous insights into respondents' thoughts (Jain *et al.*, 2021). In line with the research objectives, the interview discussion guide (Table III) was developed through brainstorming sessions, taking input from three researchers, and later verified by two experts. The discussion guide was thematically organized based on themes from existing literature, with detailed questions for each theme and a list of probing questions. A semi-structured interview with open-ended questions enables flexibility of probing while bringing forth relevant information and effectual recalling of purchase experiences (Bazi *et al.*, 2020). Rooting the study design in BRT, the interview participants were asked to elaborate upon the reasons that drive and inhibit their SHL purchases to capture their attitude and behavioral motivation, with a focus on:

- The reasons behind purchasing pre-owned luxury fashion
- Their experiences with such purchases so far
- Any inhibitions/barriers they felt while purchasing pre-owned luxury fashion

To ensure similarity in responses, proper care was taken regarding respondent comfort across both telephonic and face-to-face by building rapport and ensuring the naturalness of

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Table I.
An overview of prior secondhand luxury literature in chronological order

Study	Objective (s)	Methodology	Country	Framework/ Theory	Key findings	Brands/Product
Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen (2015)	Identify the meanings attached to secondhand luxury possessions	Qualitative	Finland	-	Highlights five themes related to secondhand luxury possessions- Sustainable Choice, Real Deal, Pre-loved Treasure, Risk Investment and Unique Find	Luxury fashion and accessories
Ryding *et al.* (2017)	Identify drivers for the growth of second-hand fashion retailing and examine attitudinal and behavioral antecedents for vintage clothing consumption	Conceptual	UK	-	Presents a critical review of key issues in second-hand and vintage consumption	Luxury and vintage clothing markets and boutiques
Turunen *et al.* (2018)	Prior literature review to explore theoretical, conceptual, empirical relationships	Conceptual	-	Consumption cycle	Secondhand luxury literature has focused on two aspects- consumer motivations and fashion and consumption trends	Luxury fashion and vintage
Cervellon and Vigreux (2018)	Factors impacting customer experience and emotions during purchase journey in offline and online	Qualitative	France	Customer journey	Pre-purchase depicts hedonic motives in offline and goal-oriented motives in online mode. Purchase depicts story-focused in-store and product-focused online. The post-purchase phase is related to memories and sharing	Fashion
Battle *et al.* (2018)	Discuss emerging second-hand business models-swapping, fashion libraries, renting and sharing; their feasibility, benefits and drawbacks	Conceptual	-	-	There is a stigma attached to second-hand fashion consumption. Educating consumers and providing risk support is crucial	Vintage fashion
Kessous and Valette-Florence (2019)	Affective and cognitive representation of luxury consumption along with antecedents and consequences of second-hand consumption on consumer–brand relationship	Qualitative and Quantitative	Finland	-	13 clusters related to cognitive and affective representations. Nature of links between concept changes contrasting firsthand and secondhand luxury products	Various first and second-hand product categories
Turunen and Pöyry (2019)	Identify and structure consumer decision-making styles used while purchasing secondhand luxury	Qualitative	Finland	Consumer decision-making styles	Seven dimensions of consumer shopping styles were identified. Confused by over-choice was apparent as confused by lack of choice. An additional dimension – resale value consciousness – was identified	Luxury accessories, mostly handbags
Turunen *et al.* (2018)	Investigate meanings attached to the process of selling luxury goods	Qualitative	Finland, France, Italy, UK	-	Five themes emerged in two categories– The personal value of selling luxury: Emotional detachment and financial empowerment and the social value of selling luxury: Sellers' enactment of social roles	Various brands and product categories

(*continued*)

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Study	Objective (s)	Methodology	Country	Framework/ Theory	Key findings	Brands/Product
Hu *et al.* (2019)	Investigates drivers for (non) participation in access-based consumption through P2P and B2C models	Qualitative	UK	-	Positive attitude toward access-based consumption. Characteristic differences between secondhand luxury and access-based consumption in other industries	Fashion
Zampier *et al.* (2019)	An articulation between second-hand trade, online marketing, virtual luxury stores and the importance of authenticity	Qualitative	Brazil	-	Although authenticity is a multidimensional concept, a relative interpretation is needed	Luxury apparel
Duarte (2020)	Exploring the creation of value-added propositions by luxury resellers in the online context and conclude the Business Model Canvas	Qualitative	-	-	The findings reveal similarities and differences between three key second-hand online players- Vestiaire Collective, The RealReal, and Rebag and maps them in each building block of the Business Model Canvas	Various product categories from Vestiaire Collective, The RealReal, and Rebag
Elias (2020)	Determine the dimensions for successful second-hand businesses	Qualitative	Portugal	-	Four major motivators were identified that consumers consider judging authenticity and good condition- lower price, uniqueness, sustainability, lifestyle	Various categories
Guzzetti *et al.* (2021)	Identify traits and engagement drivers of collaborative luxury consumers	Quantitative	Italy	Theory of reasoned action	Vintage, secondhand and rentals studied together. Similar recreational motivations exhibited in vintage and second-hand, but drivers for rentals are utilitarian	Various categories
Stolz (2022)	Identify key drivers for secondhand luxury purchase	Quantitative	Germany	Theory of planned behavior	Motivations for purchasing secondhand; role of creativity and nostalgia on purchase intention	Various categories
Jain and Rathi (2023)	Identify values driving secondhand luxury	Quantitative	India	Goal framing theory	Egoistic and altruistic values drive SHL through attitude and subjective norm with a moderating role of consumer perceived readiness	Fashion and accessories

Notes: B2C: business-to-consumer, P2P: peer-to-peer
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Table I.

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the interaction (Irvine *et al.*, 2013). A total of 34 potential respondents were approached. After the screening, 26 interviews were conducted, recorded with the respondent's permission, and transcribed verbatim. All interviews were conducted in English and lasted between 35 and 45 min. Theoretical saturation was reached after 23 interviews, and subsequent ones garnered no new insights (Creswell *et al.*, 2007). Thematic analysis extracted themes, subthemes and codes from the transcripts. NVivo software was employed to perform the analysis (Braun and Clarke, 2019). These themes followed two approaches (1) a priori approach based on prior knowledge and understanding from literature and (2) an inductive approach based on new insights from the analysis (Ryan and Bernard, 2003). In addition, three researchers independently coded the interview findings, verified the resultant factors to check for the themes' accuracy, and the themes were finalized after multiple discussions to resolve disagreements (Perry and Chung, 2016). Finally, findings from the qualitative study were integrated into a conceptual framework capturing both motivations and constraints for SHL (Figure 1).

3.2 Sample profile

The sample is diverse and representative. For the qualitative phase, respondents varied in occupation, cities of residence and were young adults ranging between 18 and 35 years of

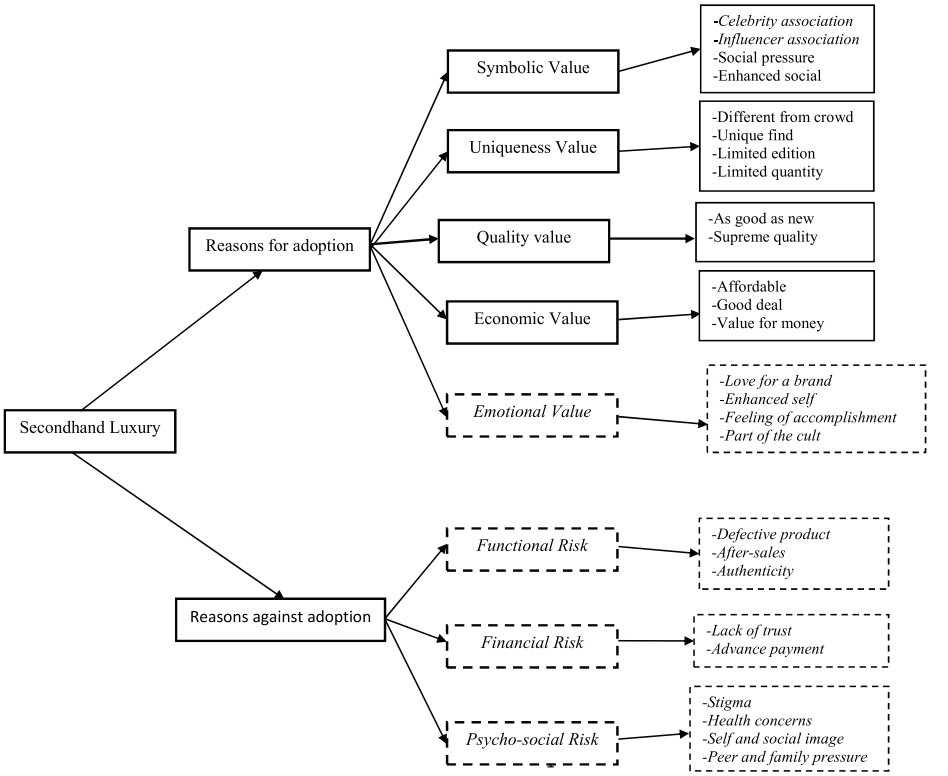


Figure 1.
Conceptual framework from qualitative analysis

Note: Dotted and italicized themes are contributions of this study and are not mapped in past literature
Source: Figure created by authors

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age. Data were collected from young adults between 18 and 35 years of age. The gender ratio accounted for 54 per cent men and 46 per cent women. Almost 50 per cent had annual household income ranging from US$16,000 to US$20,000, 23 per cent had an income ranging from US$20,000 to US$40,000, approximately 13 per cent ranging from US $40,000 to US$67,000, and the remainder had income over US$135,000. Table II captures respondent profiles.

4. Findings

Results reveal that reasons for SHL adoption are more driven by value perceptions and reasons against depicting risk-related inhibitions. A detailed thematic analysis is presented in Tables IV and V. The a priori and emergent themes are discussed below, along with exemplar quotations from the interviews.

4.1 Value perception

4.1.1 Symbolic value. India is at a nascent stage in experimenting with luxury. Enhancing social identity is as important for consumers as expressing personal meanings (Sharma *et al.*, 2021). Considering this contextual backdrop, many respondents emphasized the need for social acceptability. They said,

Respondent code	Age (years)	Gender	Occupation	Purchased pre-owned brands	City
D1	24	M	Banking services	Giorgio Armani	Ghaziabad
V1	24	M	Student	Burberry	Ludhiana
N1	25	M	Business	Prada, Burberry	Bhatinda
A1	25	M	Banking services	Tiffany & Co.	Gurugram
A2	23	F	Management trainee	Fendi, Louis Vuitton	Gurugram
S1	24	M	Business	Hugo Boss, Michael Kors	Calcutta
S2	27	F	Business	Mulberry, Chanel	Jaipur
A3	24	F	Business	Louis Vuitton	Gurugram
P1	25	M	Sales planning head	Gucci, Van Cleef & Arpels	Mumbai
R1	22	F	Student	Versace, Off White	Gurugram
R2	30	M	Business	Dior, Valentino	Jaipur
U1	25	M	Business	Chanel, Fendi	Aara
D2	20	F	Student	Hermes	Chandigarh
A4	27	F	Makeup artist	Fendi	Jaipur
L1	22	M	Student	Givenchy, Gucci	Bhatinda
S3	25	M	Banking services	Cartier	Delhi
M1	32	M	Education	Louis Vuitton, Ferragamo	Gurugram
F1	26	M	Student	Armani, Hugo Boss	Kashipur
K1	24	F	Logistics manager	Dior	Delhi
D3	21	M	Student	Coach	Vijayawada
P2	25	F	Business	Dolce & Gabbana	Chandigarh
K2	26	F	Lawyer	Saint Laurent	Noida
U2	19	M	Student	Gucci	Jaipur
D4	24	M	Banking services	Louis Vuitton, Chanel	Noida
P3	22	F	Student and freelancer	Jimmy Choo, Fendi	Mumbai
M2	26	F	Model	Armani, Louis Vuitton	Mumbai

Notes: M: male, F: female
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Table II. Details of the respondents

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Q1	*Screening question*: Do you have any experience of purchasing SHL products in the recent past, online or offline?
Q2.1	Age
Q2.2	Gender
Q3.1	What does luxury mean to you?
Q3.2	How often do you buy luxury products?
Q4.1	How long have you been buying secondhand luxury?
Q4.2	What motivates you to buy luxury from resale markets?
Q4.3	How has been your experience so far?
Q4.4	Do you think you contribute toward sustainability when you buy secondhand luxury?
Q5.1	Are there any inhibitions with respect to buying secondhand luxury?
Q5.2	What risks do you feel while buying luxury from resale markets?
Q6.1	Do you take such purchase decisions on your own or consult friends/family?
Q6.2	Do you tell your friends/family about your luxury purchases from the resale market?

Table III.
Interview protocol

Source: Table created by authors

> When you wear branded products and luxury items and once you go to your circle all these things matter and you buy expensive luxury items. Once you buy them regularly and your friends notice you, when you think of buying something of any random brand, you will feel that if you wear it in a social gathering, it will hamper your image. So, once you get into the habit and people notice you, it is a hard shift to something inferior. (S3)

Indian consumers are hugely influenced by celebrities and influencers and like following their style. The response

> There is a luxury product label plus there is another brand association [of a celebrity] with it. Like, if I wear LV, I will be like these are worn by Cardi B. And that would mean so much to me. When such a name is attached to a pre-owned luxury product, I will buy it any day. (A1)

corroborates the same.

4.1.2 Uniqueness value. Consumers express their uniqueness through luxury products. This is true even for pre-owned luxury that empowers consumers to represent themselves and stand out from the masses through possessions of unique products. In this regard, the analysis reveals various subthemes capturing Indian millennial consumer's desire to be unique and different from the crowd. Respondent (N1) shares "It has been like this with me since childhood. No kid used to wear bright neon colors, but just so that I stand out in the group, I chose strange colors and designs." Another interesting code consistent with previous studies is that of *unique findings*. Finding a unique product represents their identities, distinguishing them from the mass. Unique products are generally found in *limited edition* collections and *limited quantity* launches. Such launches enkindle Indian millennials allowing them to emulate the global trend. One respondent (N1) shares,

> I might consider something limited edition that is not available anywhere. Most shoes, like Jordans, are in limited quantity. They get launched in limited quantities in India. It is very hard to get hold of these products. So, to match the trend, I consider getting them even from the secondhand market.

4.1.3 Quality value. Unsurprisingly, quality succeeds price as a focal aspect in pre-owned fashion. Consumers naturally look for supreme quality while buying luxury fashion which accords equally for brand quality and product quality. Product quality for a pre-owned garment is viewed against its age and is a key purchase driver for Indian shoppers. The quote below from the interviewee (D1) confirms the same.

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Theme	Subtheme	Code	Example quotes
Value drivers for adoption of SHL	Symbolic value	Celebrity association	Here in India, we see a lot of actors and other celebrities and when we see them wearing something, we feel why can't we wear such a thing or why can't we be like them. (A3)
		Influencer association	If they have owned a certain luxury product and now selling it, I would love to buy it because along with the brand name their name is also attached so others might also get influenced to buy it. (A1)
		Social pressure	Once you get into the habit of it and people notice you wearing that, and when you shift to something inferior, that kind of gets to you. (S1)
		Enhanced social image	Like people when we are in a social gathering or something, you tend to be more noticeable and that is what every person wants. (S1)
	Uniqueness value	Different from crowd	Most of the time I want the thing that is unique that nobody has. (N1)
		Unique find	Like if there is a unique colour in a dress or something, I will always consider it. I can wear this neon green colour because nobody wears that. (R1)
		Limited edition	So, I almost always look for the items that are special editions and nobody has it. (N1)
		Limited quantity	Most of the shoes like Jordans and all that, they are like into limited quantity. Like they get launched in limited quantity in India. (U1)
		Trend	I tend to buy product that is very trendy just to keep pace with what is going on in the fashion world.
		Variety	I know I will wear it only once or twice and then I will be bored of it. (A4)
	Quality value	As good as new	It should look next to new if not new at least. (D1)
			Seems like okay this has been worn by you and gently used and you feel the essence that you are getting a new product. (N1)
		Supreme quality	I look up for quality. For me quality matters the most. So if the quality is good, I'm happy. (V1)
	Emotional value	Love for a brand	Like I have few favourite luxury brands and one of them is Fendi and if I see a good product, I will definitely go for it. (A2)
		Enhanced self	I feel good, I just feel nice about myself. (S1)
			The part wherein I feel good about myself is more. (A4)
		Feeling of accomplishment	It makes me feel that a little has been achieved in my life. And that is the reason why I am able to afford this. (S2)
		Part of the cult	So it's just that you are a part of the cult. You have the brand. You wear them. (P1)
		Eye catching product	If like the product I lean for the brand. It might happen that one day another, say, a company which is not there in the market, but has a good product and suddenly it pops into a luxury market and this happens in the case of Off-White. (P1)
		Aspirational brand	I look up to LV and Goyard as brands I aspire to own someday. I really connect with them at a deeper level. (V1)
	Economic value	Affordable	I see the prices, the new one goes around 20k-25k. So, it was like 6,500 was not that bad. (N1)
			Because people are getting the same quality, almost the same quality and everything but half or 3/4th the original price. (L1)
		Good deal	Definitely if I get a good deal on sunglasses watches and all these like Jordans sneakers and all Airmax Nike. (R1)
		Value for money	It is our Indian mentality whether you're earning 10k or 10 lakhs per month it totally depends on that like whether you spending whatever amount you need to make sure that it's a genuine thing I'm paying for it. (R2)

Source: Table created by authors

Table IV.
Reasons for adoption of secondhand luxury

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Themes	Subthemes	Codes	Example quotes
Risk barriers against the adoption of SHL	Functional risk	Defective product	So, in secondhand products what is there is this defect is the main problem. (A1)
		After-sales	In secondhand it is like I showed you the product earlier, now you bought it, it is yours. The sellers' job is over once sale is done. (U1)
		Authenticity	I need to make sure that he's not selling with the first copy product. (A4)
			Unless you have never got a product, and you are getting pre-owned luxury product for the first time, you have no idea about the product. (N1)
			Because nowadays duplicates and first copies are getting so good that it is literally very hard to distinguish between original and a first copy. (P1)
	Psychosocial risk	Stigma	There is a stigma that if you tell the product is second hand then the luxury around the product is vanished. (V1)
		Health concerns	But when it comes to something like jeans or t-shirt or something that sticks to the skin, a big no no. (S1)
		Self and social image	If you are working in office and hanging with colleagues and all the definitely not tell them that it is pre-owned stuff for sure. (K1)
		Peer and family pressure	But when I discussed this with my sister, she said why are you buying it? Don't buy old stuff, it is used. (F1)
			My friend suggested not to buy. Most people have a mindset that pre-owned goods and all the secondhand stuff is not good. Someone has used it. (P2)
	Financial risk	Lack of trust	A big concern is that your money can go into wrong place. (P2)
		Advance payment	I was not able to trust whether he was selling original or not because they asked money in advance. (S3)

Table V.
Reasons against adoption of SHL

Source: Table created by authors

> I look up to quality. For me, quality matters the most. It seems like, okay, this has been worn by someone and gently used, but I should feel the essence of a new product. It should look and feel like it is in mint condition. Simply put, it should look next to new if not new.

4.1.4 Emotional value. Luxury brands evoke more emotions compared to mass brands. Consumers feel associated with brands that stir their emotions and make them feel valued. If done correctly, this reaches a stage where consumers love a brand so much that they feel accomplished and emotionally triggered by making a purchase, and the brand becomes more important than the product. Reaching such a point is profitable even in the secondhand market for a luxury brand. No prior study has emphasized this aspect of SHL, making it a significant contribution to this study's exploratory phase. The evidence lies in the responses where interviewees showed a strong love for their favorite brands and a strong desire to purchase them pre-owned. Respondent (A3) explained,

> I have few favourite luxury brands, including Fendi. I feel so happy and accomplished when I wear something from this brand. This happiness is very personal. I get personal pleasure out of owning something from Fendi, even if it is secondhand.

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These emotions are even stirred when millennials associate certain luxury brands with a sense of accomplishment. Indian luxury buyers are aspirational, and their associations and emotional connections with brands reveal personal desires and identities. Emphasizing this feeling of achievement, one respondent (V1) said, "I feel I am part of the cult and when I know that very few people can afford it and wear it, it makes me think that something has been achieved in life."

Another crucial finding highlighted that not all consumers look for brands, but some even associate hedonic meanings with products, irrespective of brands. For them, hedonism lies in possessing the most distinguished products. Respondent (M1) substantiated the idea:

> It is more about the product that I get. Some time back, there was a shoe released by Balenciaga, the croc shoe. I have no aspiration of ever buying Balenciaga. But because it was a good-looking shoe, I wanted to buy it. For me, it depends on the product and not the brand. I mostly desire to get the best and unique products, no matter which brand they are.

4.1.5 Economic value. A unanimous and recurring theme from the analysis highlights economic values. Respondents agree on a general notion about pre-owned products that their financial value is lesser than new products. The analysis suggests that in India, consumers are value-conscious. They seek the best value for every penny they spend. When signaling status comes at a fraction of the price, it becomes a major driver behind pre-owned luxury sales. The following response substantiates this:

> You buy an LV for 2.5 lakhs and if you are getting it for 80000 in a pre-owned marketplace, then what is wrong with it? As an Indian, whenever you spend money, you ensure you get the full value of the price you pay. That's our Indian mentality whether you're earning 10k or 10 lakhs per month depends on whether the money you spend is giving you good value in return. (S2)

4.2 Perceived risks

In high involvement or luxury products, perceived risks largely affect the purchase decisions and cause post-purchase dissonance. Three major risks faced by consumers were identified and discussed below.

4.2.1 Functional risks. Although luxury is less about functionality and more about symbolism, consumers purchasing pre-owned luxury care about the product's functional attributes. The study finds that Indian millennials' top priorities are durability, originality, authenticity, defect-free products and after-sales services. The flipside of acquiring luxury products from a secondhand market is the fear of defective products not being visible outright. Consumers also fear a lack of luxury knowledge leading to being duped by counterfeit sellers. One respondent (F1) voices his apprehension and says,

> The most important thing is knowledge about products. Nowadays, duplicates and first copies are getting so good that it is hard to distinguish between original and fake. Unless you have never purchased a luxury product, and you are getting preowned luxury for the first time it gets risky.

Another vital concern about pre-owned luxury platforms is the unavailability of after-sales service. Consumers expect these stores to follow up on their purchases or at least entertain them in case of defects or inauthenticity. The informant (A3) raises this fear and suggests,

> If you buy a brand-new product, you would be sure that if it has anything wrong, we can go and tell them this is your product, it has a certain defect, I want a new one. But in the secondhand product, you cannot do anything about defects. It is like I showed you the product earlier, now you bought it, it is yours.

4.2.2 Psychosocial risk. Psychosocial risks correspond to reputational inhibitions consumers experience due to the despising nature of pre-owned products, especially in

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India. The idea of "utran" is culturally rooted. There is a tradition of giving old and unused clothes to domestic help or people from low socioeconomic classes as a gesture of mercy. Therefore, accepting pre-owned luxury seems distant, especially among older generations. Millennials, however, are more open to experimenting with such models, but in disguise. They aspire to experience luxury and are anxious about their image in front of significant others. One respondent (U1) explains, "There is a stigma that if you tell people the product is secondhand, the luxury around the product vanishes. If people see you shopping in a thrift store, it is looked down upon."

Moreover, Indian millennials comfortably purchase SHL accessories, but apparel is displeasing to them. This is evident when (S2) says, "For me, it is uncomfortable to think of pre-owned clothes. I would never buy secondhand jeans, t-shirts, sweaters, nothing that sticks to the skin." This even extends to seeking and respecting the opinions of family and close friends while making a purchase decision, emphasizing collectivistic culture. Respondent (P2) substantiates this by stating,

> I was eyeing a Tom Ford jacket for a long time. But when I discussed it with my sister, she asked why you were buying it? Don't buy old stuff, it is used. Because my sister didn't approve at that time, I came under a little pressure. Like her, most people believe that secondhand goods are not good. Someone has used it. And when they see someone wearing, they judge.

4.2.3 Financial risk. The financial aspect of pre-owned purchases is closely associated with trust. Respondents lack confidence in secondhand players and fear losing money if the product does not turn as expected. It would not be wrong to call it the most dominating risk perceived by Indian consumers, as their primary motivation behind buying pre-owned luxury is saving money. They seek monetary value in every purchase and link financial with functional risks. Their inhibitions accelerate when sellers do not provide return or refund options on faulty products. Respondent (A3) says, "In secondhand, you are taking a higher risk because there may be no return, exchange or refund. So, there is a big risk of money going to the wrong place." Financial risks are common across cultures, as evident from the findings of past studies in Europe. However, emerging nations exhibit higher monetary sensitivity. Thus, consumers perceive more risk and lack trust.

5. Discussion

This research synthesizes the status quo of SHL research and adds new culturally distinct insights through a qualitative study. Grounding in BRT, it uses a unified lens to advance SHL scholarship by capturing drivers and inhibitors. The major driving values pertain to symbolic aspects, uniqueness, quality, economic and emotional value, whereas three major risks – functional, financial and psychosocial – are highlighted.

The findings add to the literature on three major fronts. First, a new theme emerged as emotional value not previously reported in past studies. Emotional detachment has been highlighted as a personal value driver in the works of Turunen *et al.* (2018), where sellers feel emotionally detached from their luxury possessions and make it convenient for others to buy. But the emotional value derived from purchasing SHL has not been emphasized enough. Luxury brands evoke more emotions compared to mass brands. Consumers associate themselves with brands based on their direct and indirect experiences with that brand. Consumers feel connected to brands that stir their emotions and make them feel valued. Reaching such a point is profitable even in the secondhand market for a luxury brand. This is evident from the responses where interviewees showed a strong love for their favorite brands based on past experiences and a strong desire to purchase them secondhand. These emotions are even stirred when young consumers associate certain luxury brands with a sense of accomplishment.

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Another crucial finding this research highlights is that not all consumers look for brands, but some even associate hedonic meanings with products, irrespective of brands. For them, hedonism lies in possessing the most distinguished products. They are more drawn toward products/brands that depict congruence with their actual or desired self-concept. Indian luxury buyers are aspirational, and their associations and emotional connections with brands signal personal desires and identities. The aspects of a brand or product beyond its tangible attributes form symbolic meanings and are psychological (Smith and Colgate, 2007). Consumers associate symbolic dimensions and desirability with their luxury possessions. This is consistent with pre-owned luxury as consumers associate brand meanings and long for status in social contexts (Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen, 2015). The symbolic value may also represent associations with celebrities and influencers and following their style. Bazi *et al.* (2020) note that celebrities are regarded as credible sources and influence consumers to engage with luxury brands, and the authors' interviewees corroborate the same. Interestingly, no study conducted in the west observed celebrity and influencer associations as a major driver for purchasing pre-owned luxury. This further strengthens the purpose of a culturally diverse perspective on buying intentions as consumers in emerging nations differs significantly from those in mature economies.

Uniqueness as a purchase driver is in line with the previous work of Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen (2015), which states that a unique product enhances positive luxury experiences. Quality also finds evidence in past research and is consistent with the findings of Sihvonen and Turunen (2016); Turunen and Pöyry (2019), where quality found a supreme place as a major driver and quality-conscious consumers are considered more rational. Prior literature also pinpoints the importance of getting good deals as a major motivator (Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen, 2015), thus corroborating monetary value.

Second, it is critical to note that sustainability as an enabler of SHL consumption did not emerge as much. The findings observe a discrepancy between consumers' concern toward the environment by engaging with SHL and the primary motives behind these purchases. This incongruity could be explained by a stream of research on pro-environmental purchase decisions that have seen a significant attitude–behavior gap toward eco-friendly products meaning consumers understand sustainability. Still, it does not get reflected in their consumption choices. Furthermore, the luxury literature lacks consensus on its association with sustainability (Eastman *et al.*, 2021).

Third, the literature captures only some aspects of risks perceived by SHL buyers. The perception of these risks causes consumers to resist buying from resale markets and acts as a reason against its adoption (Jain and Rathi, 2023). The findings add a more nuanced understanding of these risks through subthemes emerging from the qualitative inquiry. Although luxury is less about functionality and more about symbolism, consumers purchasing SHL care about the product's functional attributes. This study finds that durability, originality, authenticity, defect-free products and after-sales services are top priorities for young consumers. The flipside of acquiring luxury products from a secondary market is the fear of defective products not being visible outright. Consumers also fear a lack of luxury knowledge leading to being duped by counterfeit sellers.

Another vital concern about SHL platforms is the unavailability of after-sales service. Consumers expect these stores to follow up on their purchases or at least entertain them in case of defects or inauthenticity. Another key risk emerging from the analysis is psychosocial risks, especially in India. The idea of "utran" is culturally rooted. There is a tradition of giving old and unused clothes to domestic help or people from low socioeconomic classes as a gesture of mercy (Kaur *et al.*, 2022). Accepting SHL seems distant, especially among older generations. Youngsters are more open to experimenting with such models but in disguise. They aspire to experience luxury but, at the same time, are anxious about their image in front of significant others. This even extends to seeking

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and respecting the opinions of family and close friends while making a purchase decision, emphasizing collectivistic culture.

Additionally, the financial aspect of secondhand purchases is closely associated with trust. It would not be wrong to call it the most dominating risk perceived by Indian consumers as their primary motivation behind buying SHL is saving money. They seek monetary value in every purchase and link financial with functional risks. Their inhibitions accelerate when sellers do not provide return or refund options on faulty products.

6. Conclusion

Based on qualitative research, this study offers contributions to SHL literature and practice. By delving into the academic literature on SHL, the authors reconciled existing knowledge by adding depth through themes beyond the a priori codes being captured in literature. Some values were consistent with the previous findings, while a newly observed theme, "emotional value", was added. Sustainability, which was reported to be a major adoptive reason, did not significantly emerge in this study. Another major contribution has been adding insights into the reasons against adopting SHL, denoted through risk perceptions. This piece has not received enough attention previously. Through a conceptual framework, the authors contribute to a holistic understanding of reasons for and against SHL adoption. Aside from academic research, the findings of this study should steer pre-owned luxury managers to understand consumer needs and formulate suitable strategies, the most important of which are creating awareness and building trust.

7. Implications

7.1 Theoretical implications

The findings of this research contribute to SHL literature. This paper offers fourfold implications for theory. First, as argued earlier, a lacuna existed in the literature pertaining to a holistic understanding of SHL consumption. This theoretical gap is filled by enhancing the understanding of the enablers and inhibitors (reasons for and reasons against) by analyzing the adoption (vs. resistance) of SHL. This study adds to the luxury literature by responding to the call for contributions by Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen (2015); Turunen and Pöyry (2019). While previous literature is based on consumer behavior, seller behavior and consumption cycle, this is the first study to analyze consumer motivations and inhibitions behind purchasing SHL fashion in an emerging market. This was also necessary as prior literature only focused on enablers and motivators while neglecting the equally critical inhibitors that limit consumers' engagement with SHL, especially for a young demographic in an emerging nation for luxury.

Second, this research strongly accentuates the theoretical foundations of SHL as this is the first study to ground in the BRT and present comprehensive findings for SHL consumption.

Third, by bringing forth these neglected aspects, this research is timely because SHL is quickly picking up in India as a commercial activity. This paper offer crucial insights into Indian consumer behavior on SHL, making it a culturally diverse study. India is considered a promising territory for luxury growth. The difference between Indian consumers and their Western counterparts (Jain, 2021) makes this study more generalizable and theoretically relevant in an emerging luxury market. For example, a major difference in this study compared to previous research, which is also a key contribution of these findings, is the various facets of risk perceived by Indian consumers while purchasing SHL. Some of these risks are culture-specific such as the "utran" philosophy. Similarly, the deeply rooted cultural trend of secondhand for altruistic reasons is dissimilar to the commercialized

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reasons in the West. Since this behavior is drastically different from the previous studies in the Western context, it supports the notion of differences in consumer behavior across cultures and opens avenues for future research in other emerging economies.

Fourth, for this study, the authors review the extant literature (Table I) on secondhand, pre-owned, pre-loved luxury. The pioneering study by Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen (2015) accentuates the need for global exploration on the subject. The authors' contribution toward developing a conceptual framework for a culturally diverse setting adds to the literature by capturing important value drivers and perceived risk barriers. While some a priori codes such as financial value, fashion value, uniqueness value and perceived risks are in line with past studies (Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen, 2015), the research observed an absence of sustainability and concern for the environment, otherwise an important component across studies, and the presence of emotional value that has not been highlighted so far. This supports the assumption of differences in consumer behavior across cultures and opens avenues for future research in other emerging economies.

7.2 Practical implications

This study delves deeper into the millennial consumer mindset in emerging nations, and interview probing substantiates hidden desires of Indian luxury consumers toward pre-owned fashion. Most Indian pre-owned buyers are aspirational consumers. They cannot or choose not to spend a fortune on luxury as a token of social acceptability. Rather, signaling status while saving money resonates with their attitude and values. Where globally, the resale market is booming, India, with "closet consumers" seeking value for money in all purchases, is no different. Luxury brands and conglomerates have started embracing and appreciating the new forms of consumption evident from Gucci, Stella McCartney and Burberry partnering with The RealReal (Latest Magazine, 2020), Kering acquiring a 5 per cent stake in Vestiaire Collective (Kering Finance, 2021) or Richemont acquiring watch resale platform Watchfinder (Richemont, 2018). While these may be steps toward a circular economy and sustainability from the brand's perspective, the study highlights that Indian consumers do not share the same ideologies. Indian millennials prioritize experiencing luxury at a fraction of the original price. Environmental concerns or sustainability at large do not fit into these priorities yet. This implies that brands or pre-owned sellers should align their communications to cater to what consumers consider exigent. It also posits an opportunity for these global brands to create sustainability awareness and sensitize consumers in emerging markets.

Motivational drivers reveal the predominant role of experiential purchase. Millennials expect pre-owned retail stores to reflect the aura of selling dreams while creating value like any other luxury store. The store should not be merely transactional but experiential.

A major fear inhibiting people from trusting pre-owned sellers is the online presence and absence of physical stores. Even if SHL is a high-involvement purchase, and with prevailing duping incidents, people who want to experiment with pre-owned do not. This calls for major action from pre-owned sellers and brands to consider opening experiential pre-owned stores. This can be in the form of pop-ups that Confidential Couture recently pulled off successfully for the first time in India's capital city. Such experiential stores would instill trust in online platforms by establishing an intangible association. In addition, store managers could enhance the purchase experience by providing Buy Online Pick in Store (BOPIS) and Buy Online Return in Store (BORIS) services. This model is new in India, and small steps toward truly experiential purchases would translate into customer loyalty.

Resale marketplaces face tough competition from true luxury brands entering this space and the presence of umpteen Instagram sellers, especially in the sneaker category.

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Investments and collaborations in the pre-owned models will provide an edge to brands regarding acquiring new customers, gaining their trust and curbing counterfeiting.

Unlike the previous studies in the west (Ryding *et al.*, 2017), where consumers associate pre-owned fashion with sustainability and view such purchases as ecological, responsible and a step toward "sustainable lifestyle" (Turunen and Leipämaa-Leskinen, 2015, p. 60), Indian consumers' thought process and motivations are majorly economic. Sustainability comes last on their list, and the culture of making conscious decisions about sustainable purchases is overlooked. This is counterintuitive as most pre-owned consumers are millennials and Generation Z, otherwise considered a very conscious and woke generational cohort (Rolling *et al.*, 2021). Similar responses were received when asked about sustainability as a motivation to buy pre-owned luxury during the study.

> I have never thought about it that way, but now that you have mentioned it, I think I am contributing to the environment. I might start to feel proud about it, but I won't lie, this never crossed my mind. (A2)

This mindset calls for academic researchers and pre-owned retailers to create awareness and educate young Indian consumers. They understand sustainability and sensitize to environmental issues but lack a sense of direction while making purchase decisions.

7.3 Limitations and future research

SHL research is still embryonic. Although the present study successfully initiates dialogue around this scholarship from a holistic view, certain limitations should be noted. First, this is an exploratory study that identifies only the motivations and inhibitions of consumers. As this research sets the tone for the massive scope of re-owned luxury in emerging markets, future studies can examine more nuanced aspects of consumer behavior using moderation and mediations like gender, trust or socio-demographics. Second, sustainability did not emerge as a major motivation influencing consumers to buy SHL. This calls for validation with more empirical studies effectuating more generalizable findings. Third, the findings concerning risk perceptions and house contradictions with previous studies are novel. This study with counterintuitive results demands more research with a larger representative sample for better consumer understanding associated with SHL risks. Fourth, the study is limited to SHL fashion while overlooking a massive market for other categories, such as automobiles, in which academic literature is scant. This can be a lucrative area for future studies. Finally, the cross-sectional nature of data might be prone to bias. Longitudinal and experimental studies would further enrich SHL literature.

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